



Ministry of Defence – Exchange Migration & Decommissioning Programme

The Ministry of Defence (MoD) undertook a complex, multi-phase migration programme to modernise its messaging and collaboration infrastructure.

This initiative transitioned the organisation from Microsoft Exchange 2007 to Exchange 2016, with an intermediary migration to Exchange 2013 to ensure service continuity and compliance across multiple secure environments.

Programme Overview

The programme was designed to deliver a seamless upgrade path while maintaining operational readiness across MoD sites and defence networks.

It required meticulous planning, phased execution, and strict adherence to security and governance standards.

Key objectives included:

- Modernising legacy Exchange 2007 environments
- Introducing Exchange 2013 as a transitional platform
- Migrating all mailboxes, public folders, and services to Exchange 2016
- Decommissioning legacy infrastructure post-migration
- Ensuring zero disruption to mission-critical communications

Delivery Approach

Phase 1 – Assessment & Planning

- Conducted a full audit of Exchange 2007 environments, including mailbox databases, connectors, and routing groups.
- Defined migration sequencing and coexistence strategy between 2007, 2013, and 2016.
- Developed risk mitigation plans for secure environments and classified networks.
- Produced detailed migration runbooks and rollback procedures.

Phase 2 – Intermediary Migration to Exchange 2013

- Built Exchange 2013 infrastructure to act as a bridge between legacy and modern systems.
- Configured hybrid coexistence, enabling parallel operation of 2007 and 2013.
- Migrated pilot user groups to validate performance, compatibility, and policy enforcement.
- Implemented new transport rules, retention policies, and security baselines.

Phase 3 – Full Migration to Exchange 2016

- Executed staged mailbox migrations across multiple MoD sites and secure domains.
- Integrated Exchange 2016 with Active Directory, Outlook 2016, and mobile device management.
- Delivered automated scripts for mailbox provisioning and batch migration.

- Conducted validation testing and user acceptance across departments.

Phase 4 – Decommissioning & Optimisation

- Retired Exchange 2007 and 2013 servers following successful data migration.
- Verified data integrity and compliance with MoD retention and audit policies.
- Reclaimed hardware resources and optimised storage utilisation.
- Delivered final documentation, operational handover, and support transition.

Outcomes

- Successful migration from Exchange 2007 → 2013 → 2016 across all MoD environments
- Zero downtime for mission-critical communications
- Enhanced security, scalability, and compliance
- Simplified management and improved user experience
- Full decommissioning of legacy infrastructure

Strategic Impact

The MoD Exchange Migration & Decommissioning Programme delivered a secure, modern, and resilient messaging platform aligned with defence communication standards.

By leveraging an intermediary migration to Exchange 2013, the programme ensured continuity, compliance, and operational stability throughout the transition — enabling the Ministry to operate with greater agility and confidence in its digital communications environment.